

U.S. DEPARTMENT OF AGRICULTURE
WASHINGTON, D.C. 20250

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OPI: Office of the Chief Information Officer, Cybersecurity and Privacy Operations Center	EXPIRATION DATE: June 9, 2031

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1. PURPOSE

This Departmental Regulation (DR) sets the United States Department of Agriculture’s (USDA) policy for system and information integrity (SII).

2. SCOPE

a. This DR applies to all:

- (1) Mission Areas, agencies, staff offices, and USDA personnel who work for or on behalf of USDA. The term “USDA personnel” encompasses USDA employees, appointees, contractors, partners, interns, fellows, affiliates, and volunteers;

- (2) Federal data in any medium or form that the USDA or those on behalf of the USDA generates, collects, provides, transmits, stores, maintains, or accesses;
 - (3) Systems or services, including cloud-based, that the USDA or those on behalf of the USDA use or operate. These include connections between or among data systems or services; and
 - (4) Facilities from which USDA systems operate, whether the USDA or another entity on behalf of the USDA uses or operates them.
- b. Nothing in this policy alters the need to protect national security systems or data.

3. SPECIAL INSTRUCTIONS/CANCELLATIONS

- a. This DR supersedes DR 3575-002, *System and Information Integrity*, dated August 16, 2018, in its entirety.
- b. This DR takes effect immediately when published. It remains in effect until superseded or expired.
- c. All USDA Mission Areas, agencies, and staff offices will align their SII procedures with this DR within 6 months of its publication.
- d. This DR complies with:
 - (1) [Committee on National Security Systems](#) policies, directives, and instructions;
 - (2) The *Federal Information Security Modernization Act of 2014*, [44 U.S.C. § 3551, et seq.](#);
 - (3) Federal requirements to set, implement, and enforce system integrity standards;
 - (4) Intelligence community policies, directives, and instructions;
 - (5) National Institute of Standards and Technology (NIST) [Federal Information Processing Standards Publication \(FIPS PUB\) 199](#), *Standards for Security Categorization of Federal Information and Information Systems*;
 - (6) NIST [FIPS PUB 200](#), *Minimum Security Requirements for Federal Information and Information Systems*;
 - (7) NIST, [Special Publication \(SP\) 800-37](#), Revision 2, *Risk Management Framework for Information Systems and Organizations*;
 - (8) NIST, [SP 800-39](#), *Managing Information Security Risk: Organization, Mission, and Information System View*;

- (9) NIST [Special Publication \(SP\) 800-53](#), Revision 5, *Security and Privacy Controls for Information Systems and Organizations*; and
- (10) Office of Management and Budget (OMB), [A-130](#), *Managing Information as a Strategic Resource*.

4. BACKGROUND

SII refers to ensuring the confidentiality, integrity, and availability of data systems and data. It involves managing risks from system flaws and vulnerabilities, malicious code, unauthorized code changes, and inadequate error handling. The goal is to provide assurance that someone has not tampered with or damaged the accessed data.

5. POLICY

- a. Mission Areas, agencies, and staff offices will set, implement, and maintain policies and procedures that include robust integration of SII throughout life cycle activities of all USDA data systems and services.
- b. Mission Areas, agencies, and staff offices will:
 - (1) Identify, report, and correct system flaws;
 - (2) Before installing, test software and firmware updates for efficacy and potential side effects;
 - (3) Install security-relevant software and firmware updates according to the system security plan (SSP);
 - (4) Document security-relevant changes in the associated SSP;
 - (5) Implement signature-based and non-signature-based detection mechanisms at system entry and exit points (e.g., servers, mobile devices, laptops);
 - (6) Update protection mechanisms when new releases become available;
 - (7) Configure malicious code protection mechanisms to:
 - (a) Perform periodic scans of the system weekly;
 - (b) Scan files in real-time from endpoint and network entry and exit points as they are downloaded, opened, or executed;
 - (c) Block and quarantine malicious activity; and
 - (d) Send alerts to authorized personnel only.

- (8) Address false positives during malicious code detection and the potential impact on the availability of the system;
 - (9) Configure systems to run anti-spam and anti-phishing detection solutions at system entry and exit points. This will minimize false positives and false negatives;
 - (10) Check for valid syntax and semantics (e.g., character set, length, numerical range, and acceptable values) of the system. Verify inputs match specified definitions for format and content;
 - (11) Configure systems to generate and send error messages to authorized personnel only; and
 - (12) Run Data Execution Prevention (DEP) to protect memory from unauthorized code execution.
- c. For system monitoring activities, Mission Areas, agencies, and staff offices will work with the Cybersecurity and Privacy Operations Center (CPOC) to:
- (1) Comply with applicable federal laws, E.O.s, directives, policies, regulations, standards, and guidelines;
 - (2) Employ automated monitoring tools and layered protection mechanisms;
 - (3) Continuously monitor all network traffic, as well as determined defined encrypted traffic;
 - (4) Analyze outbound traffic at interior points (subnetworks and subsystems) and external interfaces to detect covert data exfiltration and anomalies;
 - (5) Ensure authorized personnel have access to monitoring information;
 - (6) Identify network services that have not been authorized or approved and alert security personnel when detected; and
 - (7) Employ an automated alert mechanism. This will alert malicious, risky, or atypical activity to authorized personnel.
- d. Mission Areas, agencies, and staff offices will work with the CPOC Security Operations Center to continuously monitor all systems within their purview for:
- (1) Attacks, or indicators of potential attacks;
 - (2) Unauthorized local, network, and remote connections;
 - (3) Unauthorized access, use, or downloads; and
 - (4) Attempts to deny service or degrade the performance.

- e. Mission Areas, agencies, and staff offices will:
 - (1) Only accept security alerts, advisories, and directives from the USDA Chief Information Security Officer (CISO);
 - (2) Generate internal security alerts, advisories, and directives as necessary;
 - (3) Disseminate security alerts, advisories, and directives to personnel within their purview with a need to know, or those who implement the directives; and
 - (4) Follow all alert, advisory, and directive implementation timelines according to the relative USDA cybersecurity directive.
- f. Refer to the following policies related to system integrity:
 - (1) [DR 3080-001](#), *Records Management* for guidance on data retention and management;
 - (2) [DR 3505-003](#), *Access Control for Information and Information Systems* for guidance on privileged users and managing access to data systems;
 - (3) [DR 3505-005](#), *Cybersecurity Incident Management* for incident management;
 - (4) [DR 3515-002](#), *Privacy Policy and Compliance for Personally Identifiable Information* for guidance on personally identifiable information (PII) management;
 - (5) [DR 3520-002](#), *Configuration Management* for guidance on system settings and configurations;
 - (6) [DR 3530-006](#), *Scanning and Remediation of Configuration and Patch Vulnerabilities* for guidance on system vulnerability management; and
 - (7) [DR 3575-003](#), *Information Systems Log Retention Requirements* for guidance on creating, storing, and maintaining various system logs.

6. ROLES AND RESPONSIBILITIES

- a. The Cybersecurity Defense Operations Division (CDOD), Cybersecurity Watch Branch (CWB) will investigate malicious activity per [DR 3505-005](#), Cybersecurity Incident Management.
- b. The USDA Chief Information Officer (CIO) will:
 - (1) Ensure compliance with all SII-related federal guidance;
 - (2) Ensure USDA agencies have adequate resources to carry out SII requirements;

- (3) Serve as the Senior Agency Official for Privacy (SAOP) during system authorizations, oversee privacy assessment conduct, and privacy and security control implementation; and
 - (4) Report at least annually on the efficacy of deployed privacy and security program controls to all oversight bodies, as required.
- c. The USDA CISO will:
 - (1) Ensure SII control integrates with system life cycle management and all applicable processes;
 - (2) Ensure that the Department and USDA agencies develop, maintain, and comply with federal and departmental SII requirements; and
 - (3) Disseminate SII requirements and guidance to Mission Area Assistant CIOs, CISOs, and Information System Security Managers (ISSM).
- d. Mission Area Assistant CIOs will:
 - (1) Ensure personnel under their purview comply with all federal and departmental SII requirements;
 - (2) Ensure relevant personnel assess, document, implement, and manage IT security risks; and
 - (3) Serve as authorizing official for their Mission Area. Ensure all data systems, applications, or common control sets in their purview have a current authorization to operate.
- e. Mission Area Assistant CISOs will:
 - (1) Coordinate with the USDA CISO to ensure SII controls integrate with system life cycle management, and all applicable processes;
 - (2) Conduct a full assessment of implemented controls and enhancements to determine effectiveness;
 - (3) Approve rules for acceptable data usage, creation, storage, processing, sharing, and protection for which they have statutory, management, or operational authority;
 - (4) Serve as the principal data security specialist to all personnel in their purview;
 - (5) Make sure their personnel promptly respond to security alerts; and
 - (6) Ensure all personnel in their purview take annual information security awareness training per [DR 3545-001](#), *Information Security Awareness Program*, and they complete role-based training as appropriate.

f. Agency Contracting Officers will:

- (1) Ensure contract documents define the performance expectations for each required SII security control as follows:
 - (a) Describe measurable outcomes; and
 - (b) Identify remedies.
- (2) Provide response requirements for any identified compliance failure with departmental SII requirements.

g. Mission Area ISSMs will:

- (1) Ensure the personnel in their purview with SII responsibilities have awareness of and understand federal and departmental requirements;
- (2) Verify systems under their purview have appropriately addressed SII controls;
- (3) Make sure their personnel immediately report incidents to CWB and respond to CDOD inquiries and communications regarding incidents;
- (4) Inform the Mission Area, agency, and staff office head, Mission Area Assistant CIO, and the USDA CIO of significant incidents;
- (5) Coordinate with System Owners to establish roles, privileges, access levels, and required controls to protect system data that is generated, used, stored, transmitted, and processed; and
- (6) Coordinate with, and offer guidance to, USDA personnel on managing life cycle activities and data security.

h. System Owners will:

- (1) Comply with, implement, and follow policy and procedures for SII;
- (2) Coordinate with ISSM and Information System Security Officers (ISSO) in other duties assigned under other USDA directives and federal guidance;
- (3) Ensure vulnerability remediation processes integrate with configuration management processes;
- (4) Implement malicious code protection mechanisms;
- (5) Ensure mail and messaging systems deploy integrity protection mechanisms;
- (6) Ensure automatic protections respond appropriately to integrity violations;
- (7) Approve and monitor all maintenance activities;

- (8) Check their systems' inputs for valid system inputs; and
- (9) Ensure that users, including information system support staff, are trained prior to gaining access to the data system. Training must comply with [DR 3545-001](#).
- i. System and Network Administrators will:
 - (1) Comply with, implement, and follow policy and procedures for SII;
 - (2) Perform other flaw remediation-specific functions assigned to DR 3530-006;
 - (3) Ensure security-relevant software and firmware regularly update;
 - (4) Implement and maintain integrity verification mechanisms to detect unauthorized changes to systems. Follow documented processes when there are notifications of discrepancies discovered during integrity verification; and
 - (5) Review system audit records for indications of inappropriate usage. Report findings to designated officials, as specified in internal procedures.
- j. ISSO will:
 - (1) Support the System Owner in SII functions assigned in this DR. Ensure implementation of SII controls throughout the system life cycle activities; and
 - (2) Ensure collaboration to improve visibility and the detection of cybersecurity vulnerabilities and threats to the Government. This requirement appears in [E.O. 14028](#), *Improving the Nation's Cybersecurity*.
- k. All users will:
 - (1) Maintain knowledge of federal and departmental SII requirements;
 - (2) Complete annual information security awareness training, and sign rules of behavior and an acceptable use agreement;
 - (3) Review [DR 4070-735-001](#), *Employee Responsibilities and Conduct*, annually;
 - (4) Notify their supervisor if an access control vulnerability or policy violation is discovered or suspected; and
 - (5) Report any suspicious or unusual activity to their supervisor as soon as possible.

7. PENALTIES AND DISCIPLINARY ACTIONS FOR NONCOMPLIANCE

- a. DR 4070-735-001, *Employee Responsibilities and Conduct*, Section 16: *Computers*, sets forth USDA policy, procedures, and standards on employee duties and conduct regarding the use of computers and telecommunications equipment. In addition, Section 21: *Disciplinary or Adverse Action*, states:
 - (1) Any violation of the responsibilities or standards contained in this DR may be cause for disciplinary or adverse action; and
 - (2) Any disciplinary or adverse action taken will be consistent with the applicable laws and regulations.
- b. Such disciplinary actions will follow applicable laws and regulations. These include those from the Office of Personnel Management, OMB, and [5 CFR § 2635](#), *Standards of Ethical Conduct for Employees of the Executive Branch*.

8. POLICY EXCEPTIONS

All Mission Areas, agencies, and staff offices will conform to this policy. Any Mission Area, agency, or staff office that cannot meet a specific policy requirement must request a policy exception. To do so, email the OCIO CPOC SMD, Risk Management Branch at POAMProgram@usda.gov. Note that an approved risk-based decision is an acceptance of risk but does not constitute compliance.

9. INQUIRIES

Send any questions or concerns about this DR to the OCIO CPOC via CPOC-CyberPolicy@usda.gov.

-END-

APPENDIX A

ACRONYMS AND ABBREVIATIONS

CDOD	Cyber Defense Operations Division
CFR	Code of Federal Regulations
CIO	Chief Information Officer
CISO	Chief Information Security Officer
CNSS	Committee on National Security Systems
CNSSI	Committee on National Security Systems Instruction
CPOC	Cybersecurity and Privacy Operations Center
CWB	Cyber Watch Branch
DR	Departmental Regulation
E.O.	Executive Order
FIPS PUB	Federal Information Processing Standards Publication
FISMA	Federal Information Security Modernization Act
ISSM	Information System Security Manager
ISSO	Information System Security Officer
IT	Information Technology
NIST	National Institute of Standards and Technology
OCIO	Office of the Chief Information Officer
OMB	Office of Management and Budget
PII	Personally Identifiable Information
SAOP	Senior Agency Official for Privacy
SII	System and Information Integrity
SMD	Security Management Division
SP	Special Publication
SSP	System Security Plan
U.S.C.	United States Code
USDA	United States Department of Agriculture

APPENDIX B

DEFINITIONS

Access Control. The process of granting or denying specific requests. Requests can be for obtaining and using information and related information processing services. Requests can also be to enter specific physical facilities (e.g., Federal buildings, military establishments, and border crossing entrances). (Source: CNSS, [CNSS Instruction \(CNSSI\) 4009](#), Committee on National Security Systems (CNSS) Glossary)

Continuous Monitoring. Maintaining ongoing awareness of information security, vulnerabilities, and threats. This supports organizational risk management decisions. (Source: NIST [SP 800-137](#), *Information Security Continuous Monitoring (ISCM) for Federal Information Systems and Organizations*)

False Negative. An instance in which a security tool intended to detect a particular threat fails to do so. (Source: NIST [SP 800-83](#), Revision 1, *Guide to Malware Incident Prevention and Handling for Desktops and Laptops*)

False Positive. An instance in which a security tool incorrectly classifies benign content as malicious. (Source: NIST SP 800-83, Revision 1)

Flaw. Imperfection or defect. (Source: NIST [SP 800-160](#), Revision 1, *Engineering Trustworthy Secure Systems*)

Impact. The effect on organizational operations, organizational assets, individuals, other organizations, or the Nation (including the national security interests of the United States) of a loss of confidentiality, integrity, or availability of information or a system. (Source: NIST [SP 800-53](#), Revision 5)

Integrity. Guarding against improper information modification or destruction and includes ensuring information non-repudiation and authenticity. (Source: NIST SP 800-53, Revision 5)

Malicious Code (or Malware). Software or firmware intended to perform an unauthorized process that will have adverse impact on the confidentiality, integrity, or availability of an information system. A virus, worm, Trojan horse, or other code-based entity that infects a host. Spyware and some forms of adware are also examples of malicious code. (Source: NIST [SP 800-128](#), *Guide for Security-Focused Configuration Management of Information Systems*)

Potential Impact. The loss of confidentiality, integrity, or availability could be expected to have a limited adverse effect (FIPS PUB 199 low); a serious adverse effect (FIPS PUB 199 moderate); or a severe or catastrophic adverse effect (FIPS PUB 199 high) on organizational operations, organizational assets, or individuals. (Source: NIST SP 800-53, Revision 5)

Technical Vulnerability Information. A hardware, firmware, communication, or software flaw that leaves a computer processing system open for potential exploitation, either externally or internally, thereby resulting in risk for the owner, user, or manager of the system. (Source: CNSSI 4009)

APPENDIX C

AUTHORITIES AND REFERENCES

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